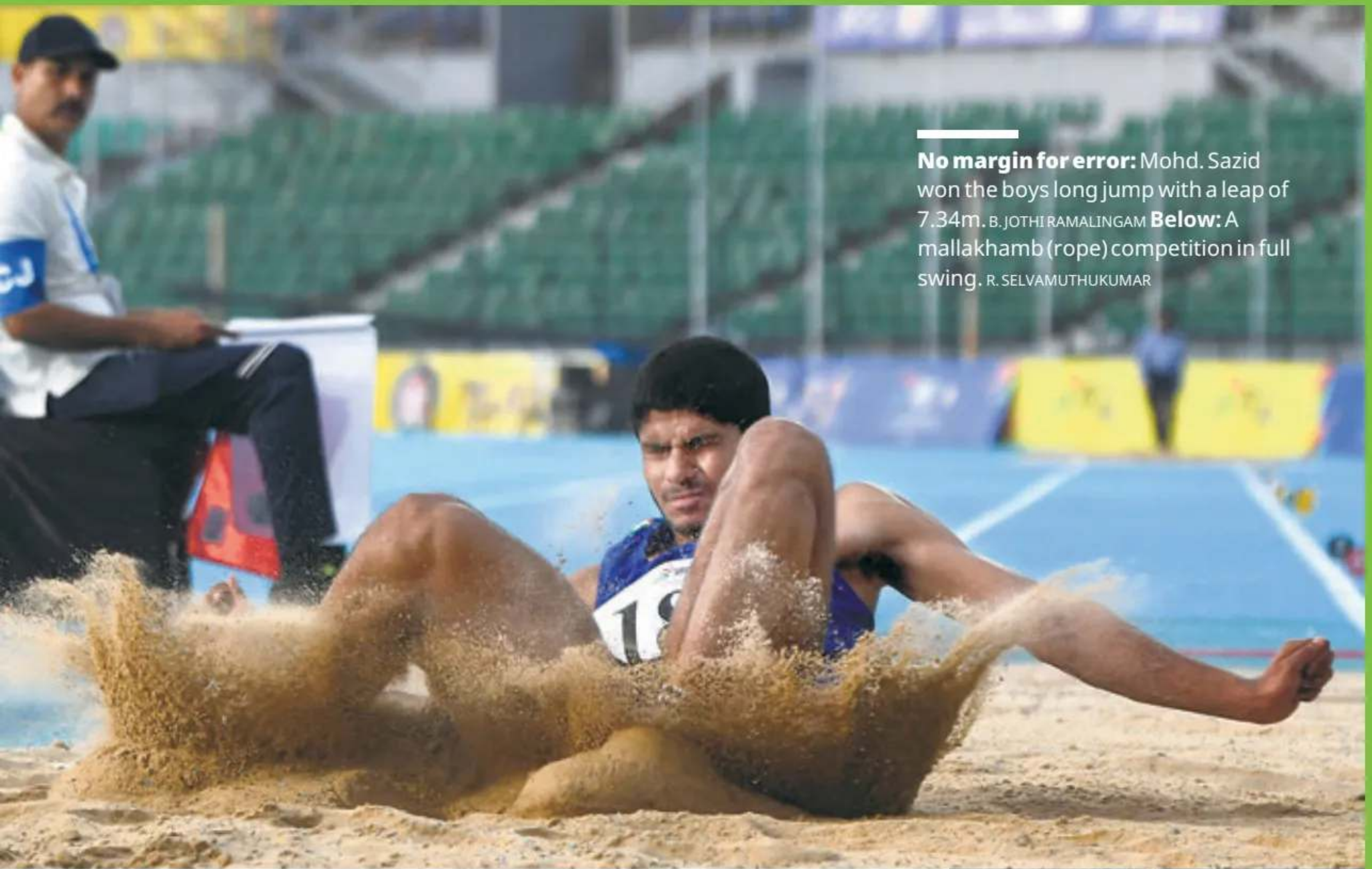




**No margin for error:** Mohd. Sazid won the boys long jump with a leap of 7.34m. B. JOTHIRAMALINGAM **Below:** A mallakhamb (rope) competition in full swing. R. SELVAMUTHUKUMAR

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**A**s a concept, the Khelo India Youth Games (KIYG) is far-reaching and impactful as it gives a certain shape and vigour to grassroot sports.

The sixth edition of KIYG, which witnessed over 5000 sportspersons from 26 disciplines taking part in competitions spread across four cities — Chennai, Coimbatore, Madurai and Tiruchirappalli, was a gamechanger in many ways.

It was a huge organisational success with the Tamil Nadu Government and Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT) deservedly claiming all the accolades. Added to it, the host's athletes did well in the sporting arena, finishing third, its best-ever in the Games.

Mercy Regina, General Manager of SDAT, insisted that without the Government's support the Games wouldn't have been such a huge success. "For almost all the sports

and games, we bought new equipment of international and national standard. Several stadiums were also renovated."

She said KIYG has created a lot of awareness about sports and games, which will go a long way in encouraging the next generation of sportspersons to win medals at the Olympics and other major international events.

Regina admitted that the maintenance of stadiums across the state remains a challenge but said that the Government has allocated an amount for its upkeep. "That will not be a problem anymore," she said.

According to her, the selection Committee of KIYG, in consultation with SDAT, has chosen three sports — fencing, boxing and athletics — and has created the State Centre of Excellence inside the Nehru Stadium premises in Chennai. "Our new building will soon be ready. We are in the process of selecting players," she said.

Cash incentives, which are essential for sportspersons to grow, have been given by SDAT and Khelo

